

Fellowship Based on Grace and Sonship

Many teachers have believed Romans 7 describes a spiritually alive, born-again believer simply having trouble with his flesh. They use that to explain statements like, "The good that I would do, I cannot," and, "That which I would not, that I end up doing."

But Romans 7 is addressed to the Jewish community in Rome:

"I speak to them that know the law."

Paul is speaking of an unregenerated Jew who received the law and could not keep it. As long as I believed Romans 7 described a born-again man having a flesh struggle, the whole book of Romans stayed locked to me.

Once the Spirit of God revealed that Romans 7 was the law-bound, spiritually dead man, Romans 8 began to open.

Romans 8:11 says:

"But if the Spirit of him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in you,
he that raised up Christ from the dead
shall also quicken your mortal bodies
by his Spirit that dwelleth in you."

We usually preached this as the Holy Spirit quickening the mortal body. But after assimilating Romans 1 through 8, I saw that Paul is talking about the born-again spirit, the new nature that quickens your body against sin.

It is wonderful to know the Holy Spirit is present with power. But it is another degree of freedom to know that your new nature itself quickens your mortal body. You do not need another nature added to stop sin. You need to acknowledge the new nature you already received.

That is why Romans 8:26 says:

"Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities."

"Also" means something else has already helped: the new nature. The Holy Spirit comes to enforce what you have already been made.

Romans 8:11 says, "the Spirit of Him that raised up Jesus from the dead." Why did Paul not simply say "the Holy Spirit"? Because he is talking about the spirit that is of the Father, the life that raised Jesus from death to life.

John 5 says:

"As the Father hath life in himself;
so hath he given to the Son to have life in himself."

That cannot be speaking of Jesus' eternal deity being created. The deity of Jesus always existed. He prayed:

"Glorify thou me with thine own self
with the glory which I had with thee before the world was."

The life the Father gave the Son was the life in His human spirit. A son must be fathered. Jesus' humanity had a beginning, though His deity did not.

The Son then quickens whom He will. The same life the Father gave the Son is the life the Son gave you when you were quickened together with Him.

Romans 8:12 says:

"Therefore, brethren,
we are debtors,
not to the flesh,
to live after the flesh."

That debt was canceled when I received a new nature. The old man that spiritual death held was crucified with Christ. The law of the Spirit of life, the law of the born-again spirit, freed me from the law of sin and death.

The devil can send a bill that says I have to sin, but it was paid in full by the new nature. I am not taking counsel from the one whose end is already written.

As for me, I am free.

If the devil could collect on that old debt, he would have collected before now. I have read the end of the Book. He is going one place, and I am going another. Why would I take counsel from someone who lived with God and rebelled against Him? The more he screams, the more trouble I know he is in.

Romans 8:13 says:

"For if ye live after the flesh, ye shall die:
but if ye through the Spirit do mortify the deeds of the body,
ye shall live."

If you live after the flesh, the unregenerated nature, you will die. But through the born-again spirit, you mortify the deeds of the body. When the body is tempted and looks for help, it meets the new nature.

Then the Holy Spirit also comes to help your weaknesses. But you must understand that you are free. Your knowledge of that freedom is what gives the Holy Spirit something to work with.

Paul already explained this in Romans 7. When the Jew was in the flesh, the motions of sin were stirred by the law. The law said, "Thou shalt not," and the spiritually dead nature could only bring forth fruit unto death. The law was not sin; it was a schoolmaster. It showed a spiritually dead man what he could not see by nature.

How can a man know anything outside the nature he was born with? I think of my wolf, Cain. He picked up our pygmy goat by the ribs and started walking away with her while she cried. I told him, "Cain, put her down." He put her down because I restrained him, but he looked at me as if to say, "You are the leader here because you feed me, but you have to understand: I am a wolf. We eat farm animals. That is what we do."

Law could restrain him for a moment, but it could not change his nature. The only way Cain could stop being that kind of creature would be for someone to put a new nature in him. That is what the new birth did for us. The old man was crucified with Christ. The part that spiritual death held was canceled.

Romans 8:14 says:

"For as many as are led by the Spirit of God,
they are the sons of God."

Paul is still arguing between covenant and sonship. The spiritually dead man had the old nature capture his mind and lead him as a slave to sin. The born-again man has a new nature that can lead his mind into righteous works and service to God.

As many as are led by that new nature are the sons of God.

The first clear mention of the Holy Spirit comes next:

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit,
that we are the children of God."

There Paul mentions both: His Spirit and our spirit.

That little word "also" in verse 26 matters. It means the new nature has already set us free, and the Holy Spirit has come alongside to enforce what we have been made.

This is one reason we separated ourselves into these morning services. There is more in the Word than we can always cover in the main services, where the Good Shepherd may go after the lost, move through gifts, preach evangelistically, or minister to every level of person in the room. In these classes, we can take time to see how free we really are.

Romans 8:15 says:

"For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear;
but ye have received the Spirit of adoption,
whereby we cry, Abba, Father."

The spirit of bondage again to fear was the nature inherited from Adam, the spirit of this world. Before regeneration, God was not your Father by nature. Jesus told unbelieving Jews:

"Ye are of your father the devil."

That is hard to say, but true: spiritual death had another father.

Now you have received the spirit of adoption. Your spirit went from death to life, and you were adopted out of Adam's family into God's family. His Spirit now bears witness with your spirit that you are His child.

I understand adoption through my own family. Tawny and Daniel were adopted. Tawny is Filipino and Chinese, and people would see her with me and Rosalie and ask if she was adopted. She learned to say, "I used to be."

The adoption process was completed. She became a full-fledged Roberson, with full inheritance. Do you think Tawny and Daniel have to get their adoption papers out to ask for a meal from the refrigerator? No. They are my son and daughter.

The New Testament is the will Jesus died to put into force and rose to administer. Once you have inherited, you do not keep waving the will in God's face. You are a beneficiary. You are a son.

Jesus, the Firstborn, received the full inheritance, then made you a joint heir with Himself.

In the Jewish family, the oldest son received the inheritance. Jesus sat down at the right hand of the Father, quickened you together with Himself, seated you in heavenly places with Himself, and made you a joint heir with Himself. He that sanctifies and those who are sanctified are one; for that reason, He is not ashamed to call us brethren.

So how do I approach God? I approach Him as a son and a joint heir with Jesus. I do not come as a stranger trying to earn something. I come as a son who says, "Father, I need to reach another nation. Put it into my account. I am ready to do the work You sent me to do."

I do not have to check my giving records to see whether He deposited it. All I am and all I have is His because He is my Father, and all He has is mine because I am His son. That is inheritance. You cannot earn a single thing. You can only prove faithful so you are not a rebellious son squandering inheritance.

It is sad when a son makes absolutely sure of his own creature comforts before he even thinks about the gospel. God wants His creation back, and He has asked us to help. Get the motive straight, and then He can bless the work.

The older brother in the prodigal son story had relationship with the father but never entered fellowship. He worked, never transgressed, and became angry when the younger son came home and the father celebrated.

The younger son broke relationship, but when he returned, relationship was restored and fellowship followed immediately. He knew his father by grace.

The older brother said, "I have served you faithfully, and you never killed the fatted calf for me." The father could have killed it every day, but the older brother never knew him well enough to ask from fellowship.

The Holy Spirit wants you to enter the celebration. He wants to lead you out of legalism and into fellowship based on grace and sonship.

The older brother was honorable in one sense. He had not transgressed. But he based fellowship on that record, and legalism made him angry at grace. The Holy Spirit went out, as it were, to bring him into the celebration. If he could have entered the worship, the dancing, the rejoicing over a father so full of grace, the thing in him that was angry at the younger brother could have been burned out.

That is what grace-based fellowship does. It does not despise obedience, but it refuses to make obedience the price of a father's love.

Do not run from the Word. Do not run from prayer, deep praying in tongues, and hours of worship. If pressure comes against your prayer closet, it is because there are things in you the enemy does not want to release.

Stay in the fellowship. Worship and pray until God burns the legalistic walk out of you and you become a grace man, walking with the Father in inheritance.

You do not have to prove your works to God. Show Him your walk. Let the Holy Spirit bear witness that you can call Him Abba.

If fear and creature comforts dominate you, you will draw up under legalism. You will stand in the field like the older brother, angry because God seems to be blessing someone who just came out of the far country. But the Father is calling you into fellowship too.

Stay in the closet. Keep worshiping. Keep praying in tongues. Let Him lay hold of everything that stands between you and that kind of fellowship, until you can walk with the Father in full inheritance and grace.

Romans 8:16-17 says:

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit,
that we are the children of God:
And if children, then heirs;
heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ."

Paul says children, not merely sons. A child crawls into the Father's lap with trust. That is how He wants to teach you: as Abba, Father.

If you are a child of God, then you are an heir of God. Because you are an heir of God, you are a joint heir with Jesus Christ.

Romans 8:18-19 says:

"For I reckon that the sufferings of this present time
are not worthy to be compared with the glory
which shall be revealed in us.
For the earnest expectation of the creature
waiteth for the manifestation of the sons of God."

What sufferings? We are still wearing bodies from the first Adam. Our spirits have received sonship, but our bodies are still waiting for the adoption process to be completed.

The sufferings caused by this unglorified body, the fight for prayer, fasting, obedience, and victory, are not worthy to be compared with the moment we receive glorified bodies as joint heirs with Christ. Flesh can scream, fight prayer, resist fasting, and try to drag us back into sin, but it cannot compare with what is already on our account because Jesus has risen from the dead.

Creation is waiting for the manifestation of the sons of God. When the adoption process is complete and we receive bodies from the last Adam, the first instant of that glorification will outweigh all the suffering the flesh ever caused.

It will be worth it.

The beginning of that manifested sonship walk will be greater than a whole lifetime of the flesh fighting you. When spirit, soul, and resurrected body are complete in Him, the first moment of glorification will not even begin to compare with all the suffering that came before it.